

Corucia zebrata

Solomon Islands tree skink



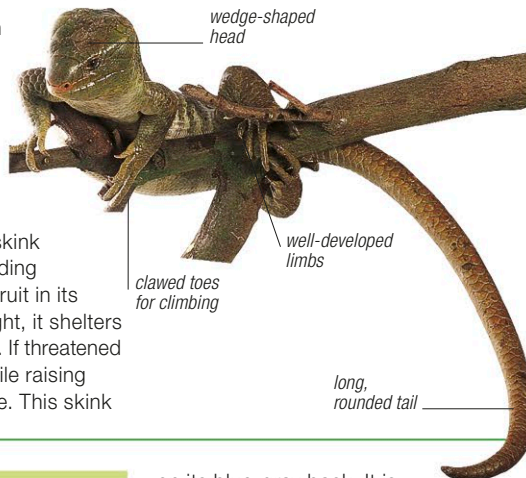
Location Solomon Islands

Length Up to 30 in (75 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Not evaluated



This olive-green or grayish green skink is a highly unusual lizard in many ways. It is very large, with a massive, wedge-shaped head and a long, prehensile tail. Unlike other skinks, the Solomon Islands tree skink is entirely herbivorous, feeding exclusively on leaves and fruit in its forest habitat. Active at night, it shelters in tree holes during the day. If threatened or provoked, it will hiss while raising itself up, and may even bite. This skink

is a long-lived species. Although little is known about its reproductive and social behavior, it is likely to be monogamous and appears to live in small family groups or loose colonies. Males and, to some extent, females are highly territorial. A female gives birth to one, occasionally 2, huge young—about one-third the size of the adult—which stays with its very protective mother for several weeks or even months. The low reproductive potential of this skink makes it vulnerable, although it is not currently a protected species.

*Eumeces schneideri*

Berber skink



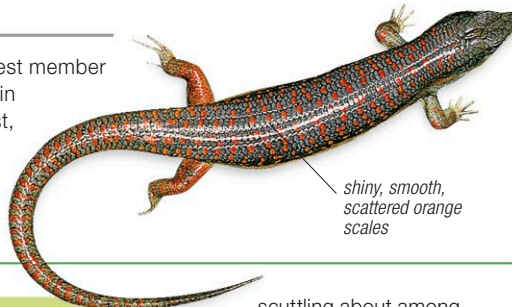
Location N. Africa to W. Asia

Length 16–18 in (40–45 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial/Burrowing
Status Not evaluated



The Berber skink is the largest member of its genus, which is found in North Africa, the Middle East, Asia, and the Americas. Bulky and with a squarish cross section, it has distinctive orange scales

on its blue-gray back. It is often found in cultivated land and semidesert, where it digs burrows at the base of shrubs. When attacked, it retreats into its burrow, or may jump into water. Active and quick-moving, the Berber skink forages for insects, spiders, snails, and smaller lizards. It shelters from the sun in the middle of the day and may not emerge on cold winter days. Females lay 3–20 eggs, coiling around them until they hatch.

*Plestiodon lagunensis*

Pink-tailed skink



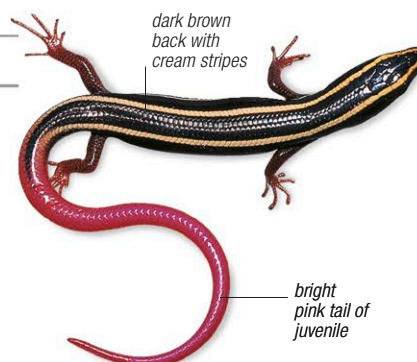
Location Mexico (Baja California)

Length 6½–8 in (16–20 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern



Also known as the San Lucas skink, this species is characterized by a long, pink tail that is bright in juveniles but faded in adults. The reason for this coloration is unclear, but it may help to divert predators toward the tail—which can be discarded—instead of toward more vulnerable parts of the body. The pink-tailed skink is a secretive animal,

scuttling about among leaf litter or vegetation—where it searches for insects and spiders—or hiding under stones. It is active year-round, although less so during Baja California's brief winters. The female lays 2–6 eggs in tunnels in loose soil. She stays with them until they hatch, and may even move them if they are threatened by unfavorable conditions, such as floods.

*Lamprolepis smaragdina*

Emerald tree skink



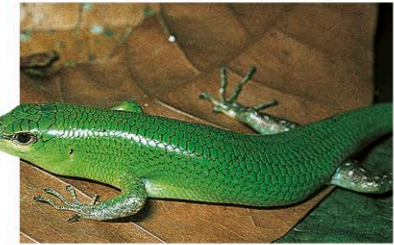
Location S.E. Asia, New Guinea, Pacific islands

Length 7–10 in (18–25 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Not evaluated



The bright green emerald tree skink has a stocky body with a long, tapering tail, a pointed snout, and smooth, shiny scales. It lives on the trunks and among

the foliage of large forest trees, and actively forages for insects, which it catches in a rapid, darting movement. If attacked by birds of prey or snakes—its main predators—this lizard will shed its tail in order to escape from its aggressor. Males are territorial and females lay 9–14 eggs.

*Bellatorias frerei*

Major skink



Location S. New Guinea, N. and E. Australia

Length 23½–28 in (60–70 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated



The major skink is one of 20 closely related species that are found in Australia and New Guinea. Like most of its relatives, it has a chunky appearance, with a body that is squarish in cross section, a thick

neck, short head, and muscular limbs. Its coloration is dark brown, becoming darker on the flanks, with a white, yellow, or orange underside. The body scales are smooth and glossy, and there are fine lines running down its back. The major skink can be seen basking in the sun or foraging for insects and small vertebrates during the day around the bases of large, buttressed trees, logs, or near rocky outcrops, never too far from cover. Females give birth to up to 6 young, which have scattered white dots on their flanks—these spots disappear as the lizard matures. Within Australia, the major skink is commonly found in forests in northeast New South Wales, islands of the Torres Straits, and Arnhem Land (Northern Territory).

*Eutropis longicaudata*

Long-tailed skink



Location S.E. Asia

Length 12–14 in (30–35 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated



The most distinctive feature of this slender skink is its extremely long tail, which can be up to twice the length of the body and head combined. The body scales are shiny and brown, and the flanks are darker brown or black. This lizard lives in clearings and gardens, often near water, and also in

coastal scrub. An active forager, it frequently pokes its snout into leaf litter and debris where insects and spiders may be found. Little is known about its reproductive behavior, but most related species give birth to 5–10 young. The genus *Eutropis*, to which it belongs, contains egg-laying as well as live-bearing species.

